

Social contagion



A visualization of social network analysis (SNA). In the 21st century, much of the study of social contagion involves online networks and communities.

Social contagion involves behaviour, emotions, or conditions spreading spontaneously through a group or network.

Two broad divisions of social contagion are behavioural contagion and emotional contagion.

Much recent work involves academics from social psychology, sociology, and network science investigating online social networks such as influence on shopping choices, and even on positive effects like the tendency for people to take action on climate change once a sufficient number of their neighbours do.

Scholars have long reported that the study of social contagion has suffered from the lack of a widely accepted and precise definition. Definitions have often, though not always, classified social contagion as a method of transmission that does not rely on a direct intent to influence. Other definitions have suggested that social contagion involves spontaneous imitation of others, rather than being based on conscious decisions.

Social contagion can be broadly split into behavioural contagion and emotional contagion.

The spread of ideas is sometimes considered a third broad category, though contagion can be split into six subcategories: hysterical contagions, deliberate self-harm contagions, contagions of aggression, rule violation contagions, consumer behaviour contagions, and financial contagions.[2][5][3]

Three main causes of social contagion have been proposed: *disinhibitory contagion*, *echo contagion*, and *hysterical contagion*.

Disinhibitory contagion involves a type of behaviour that the person already has some desire to engage in, but from which normally they would refrain due to a desire to comply with social norms.

When they witness others in the crowd performing the behaviour, this can break the inhibitory effect.

Echo contagion represents the spontaneous imitation of a behaviour, or transition into conformance with an emotional state shared by others.

Hysterical contagion represents the unwanted transmission of a behaviour, emotion or affect among a group by unknown means. Unlike with echo or disinhibitory contagion, what is being transmitted may in no way be desirable or attractive, yet it transmits anyway.

Exposure

Social contagion can be examined with threshold models based on how much exposure an individual needs before transmission of a behaviour or emotion occurs. Some models assume an individual needs to be convinced by a fraction of their social contacts above a given threshold to adopt a novel behaviour. Therefore, the number of exposures will not increase chances of contagion unless the number of source exposures pass a certain threshold. The threshold value can divide contagion processes to two types: *simple contagion* and *complex contagion*.

In *simple contagion*, an individual only needs a single exposure to the new behaviour. For instance, cars travel in groups on a two-lane highway since the car in each cluster travels at a slower speed than the car behind it. This relative speed spreads through other cars who slow down to match the speed of the car in front.

In *complex contagion*, the individual needs to be in contact with two or more sources exhibiting the novel behaviour. This is when copying behaviours needs reinforcement or encouragement from multiple sources. Multiple sources, especially close friends, can make imitation legitimate, credible and worthwhile due to collective effort put in.

Positive contagions

For example, the rippling of happiness through a social network, up to three degrees of separation from the initiator. The contagion effect of happiness is also strongly influenced by physical proximity. Research based on the Framingham Heart Study found that if one has a happy friend living no more than a mile away, they are 25% more likely to be happy, whereas one is 34% more likely to be happy with a happy next-door neighbour. Such as the increased

tendency to install solar panels on one's personal home once a portion of one's neighbours have already done so.